

DCLT Portal — Roadmap and Open Questions

Last updated: April 30, 2026. Expected to churn. Not architecture — see

DCLT_Portal_Conceptual_Architecture.md for the model.

Purpose

Project-shaped companion to the Conceptual Architecture. The CA defines the model; this doc tracks the work the model is being applied to: what Dave asked for, what data each piece needs, what's settled, what's still open. Pulls forward from the email thread that initiated the project and the conversation that distilled it.

Workstreams

Ten workstreams emerged from Dave's framing, ordered roughly from most-specified to fuzziest. Each carries a goal, the data needed, and what's open.

1. Cross-check

Goal. Compare what the Registry of Deeds, the Town of Dennis Assessor's database, and the MassGIS Openspace datalayer each say about the same parcel. Discrepancies are the deliverable — Dave frames this as a goal in its own right, not just a step toward ranking.

Downstream consumers Dave named. APCC's *Hanging in the Balance* report, Cape Cod Commission's protected-acreage analyses, wastewater siting consultants. Upstream notification targets: the Assessor and MassGIS.

Sources. Registry of Deeds, Town of Dennis Assessor database, MassGIS Openspace.

Specific measure. A discrepancy list with provenance — detailed enough that the Assessor and MassGIS can act on it without going back to source.

Open. Output format Dave's downstream users would actually consume. Cadence of regeneration as sources update.

2. Undeveloped

Goal. Filter parcels by Assessor state class code list.

Sources. Town of Dennis Assessor database.

Specific measure. Binary in-or-out on the code list: 1300, 1320, 2010(?), 2020, 3900, 3910, 3920, 4400, 4420, 9300, 9500.

Open. Confirm 2010 — Dave flagged it himself.

3. Underdeveloped

Goal. Surface parcels where built footprint is small relative to parcel acreage, with exceptions that explain why a low ratio doesn't mean development potential (mostly wetland, already restricted).

Sources. Building footprint dataset. Two candidates: a basic version and a preferred version that includes roads and driveways. Dave flagged the preferred dataset may need to be requested from Town GIS staff or the Cape Cod Commission.

Specific measure. Continuous ratio: footprint area ÷ net acreage. Threshold for "underdeveloped" is open. Exception surfacing is part of the measure, not a downstream filter.

Open. Footprint dataset acquisition — whether Dave requests or Ford does. Threshold value. How exceptions get surfaced (separate Tag dimension? Note? Layer flag?).

4. Subdividability

Goal. Evaluate whether zoning would actually support splitting a parcel — converts "underdeveloped" from a static observation into a forward-looking signal about development pressure.

Sources. Parcel geometry (Assessor / GIS), Dennis zoning bylaw dimensional requirements (frontage, lot-size minimums, district-specific rules).

Specific measure. Boolean per parcel, with the limiting constraint named (frontage, area, etc.) when subdivision is precluded.

Open. Whether the zoning bylaw is published in a form that's computable, or whether it's a PDF-extraction job. Handling of overlay districts and special permits.

5. Farming opportunity

Goal. Pull together the relevant information to support an expert judgment on a parcel's farming potential. Leeza-led workstream.

Sources. Prime Farmlands layer. Parcel characteristics (size, soils, frontage, water access). Local context the expert wants in front of them.

Specific measure. Per-parcel information packet rather than a score. Output is decision

support, not determination.

Open. What goes in the packet — Leeza to define. Whether output is per-parcel UI or a generated artifact.

6. Regulatory exposure

Goal. Workflow that puts the relevant regulatory information in front of an expert to estimate development risk — assembled per parcel rather than scored automatically.

Sources. Assessor's buildable determination, wetlands layers, zoning and overlay districts.

Specific measure. Per-parcel information packet, similar to Farming opportunity — expert-judgment support, not a calculated score.

Open. What "exposure" means operationally — likelihood of development, feasibility of development, or regulatory permissiveness. Expert identity and rubric.

7. Existing protection

Goal. Rubric for evaluating the level of permanent protection a parcel carries. At-risk properties (low durability) evaluated first.

Sources. Registry of Deeds documents tied to each parcel, classified by what they actually restrict and how durably.

Calibration set Dave provided (three RoD examples). A Doctor Stanton Rd town special permit (zoning approval), a Strawberry Lane HOA covenant with common open space, and a grantor-waivable aesthetic restriction. Two are the same Nyberg 12-lot subdivision captured through different document types; one is an earlier Nyberg project. None are M.G.L. c.184 §31 conservation restrictions. Calibration intent: keyword-matching "restriction" or "open space" conflates very different things, and a single parcel can carry several at once.

Specific measure. Per-parcel durability rubric — multi-tier, not binary. Volunteer determination is the workflow that turns OCR hits into classified protection findings.

Open. The rubric itself — what tiers, what counts as which. Whether durability is one Tag dimension or several (e.g. restriction type x waivability).

8. Conservation value

Goal. Composite ecological score per parcel. Most fully specified of the wishlist items — Dave itemized the inputs and their dual-form encoding.

Sources and dual-form encoding (binary OR continuous, per Dave).

- Parcel size (continuous)

- Abutting protected open space — presence/absence OR acreage
- Priority Habitat of Rare Species (PHRS) — presence/absence OR area. *State will update this layer in the coming fall.*
- BioMap Core — presence/absence OR area
- BioMap Critical Natural Landscape — presence/absence OR area
- BioMap Local Landscapes — same, lower weighting
- Certified vernal pools — presence/absence (higher weighting)
- Potential vernal pools — presence/absence (lower weighting)
- Zone II water supply protection area — presence/absence OR Zone II acreage

Specific measure. Composite score per parcel. Inputs are crisp; combination is open.

Open. Weighting methodology. Dave handed the FY-27 land grant rubric as a *reference*, not a commitment — see <https://www.mass.gov/doc/fy-27-land-grant-bid-document/download> (page 21). Whether to expose weights as user-tunable sliders or fix them.

9. Other ideas

Goal. Support criteria DCLT has historically applied beyond the conservation-value composite.

Trail connectivity. Sources: AllTrails, Town of Dennis trail layers. Example Dave cited: Plashes. **Viewsheds.** Likely a mix of named local features and parcel context for an expert to weigh. No clean dataset identified. **Particular habitat types of interest.** TNC's NE Habitat Map.

Open. Whether each is a Tag dimension, a Layer, or both. Which deserve their own workstream vs. folding into Conservation value.

10. New criteria

Goal. Criteria the FY-27 state rubric weights but DCLT hasn't historically applied. Open question whether DCLT adopts them — Dave flagged this as a meeting question, not a build question.

Sources. EJ Communities (state demographic data), TNC Resiliency Tool.

Open. Adoption decision. If adopted, integration into Conservation value or as parallel composite.

Cross-cutting open issues

Footprint dataset acquisition. Dave asked whether to request from Town GIS or CC Commission. Pending.

Heritage Hub workshop. Mentioned by Dave in original email; status unclear.

OCR keyword vocabulary. Currently Ford's draft, tuned to overflag. Refinement is a meeting topic — which terms matter, how to weight, whether OCR is the right hammer for some document types.

Weighting methodology for composites. FY-27 rubric is reference, not commitment. Decision deferred.

Volunteer triage UI. The three-pane parcel view is the primary surface today. Document-centric review and cover-page hygiene rollups are near-term. Open: how volunteers are onboarded to the determination workflow.

Rhythm. Dave proposed exploratory pass → meeting → refined questions → repeat. No meeting cadence locked.

Domain sources reference

Active sources, with role:

Parcel and property data.

- Town of Dennis Assessor database (parcel-level attributes, state class codes)
- Town of Dennis GIS (parcel geometry, possibly footprints)
- Registry of Deeds (recorded documents, OCR-processed)

Conservation and ecological layers.

- MassGIS Openspace datalayer (protected lands inventory; known to have errors in Dennis)
- BioMap Core / Critical Natural Landscape / Local Landscapes
- Priority Habitat of Rare Species (PHRS)
- Certified vernal pools, potential vernal pools
- Zone II water supply protection areas
- TNC NE Habitat Map

- TNC Resiliency Tool
- Prime Farmlands layer

Regulatory and demographic.

- Dennis zoning bylaw (form TBD)
- Wetlands layers
- EJ Communities

Trail and recreation.

- AllTrails
- Town of Dennis trail datalayers

DCLT-internal.

- Dave's DCLT ownership spreadsheet (mailed occasionally; arrives as a feed)

Reference frameworks (not data sources).

- M.G.L. c.184 §31 (conservation restrictions, statutory reference)
- FY-27 land grant rubric (weighting reference, page 21)
- APCC *Hanging in the Balance* report (downstream consumer of cross-check)

What this doc is not

Not architecture — that's the CA. Not a deliverable list with dates — workstreams progress at the rhythm Dave proposed (exploratory pass → meeting → refined questions). Not exhaustive — items get added as they surface in conversation, dropped as they resolve.